

Lab 01: Foreign Giving Analysis - Strategic Report for UVA's Office of Development

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Executive Summary

After digging through the foreign gifts dataset, the big picture is that UVA is doing fine but not great when it comes to international philanthropy. We sit around the 68th percentile of all US institutions in total dollars received, but only 10th out of 11 comparable public flagships, and the gap between UVA and schools like Michigan and Berkeley has been growing. The good news is that the data points to some pretty specific opportunities: UVA currently has active donor relationships with only 15 countries, compared to 20-40+ for many peers. Countries like China, Canada, Germany, Saudi Arabia, and Hong Kong currently give UVA no money even though peer schools are bringing in millions from them. My main recommendation is to focus on a short list of these countries that don't give UVA any money while also pushing harder on sponsored research and contract relationships, where UVA is especially behind.

Summary of Findings

Looking at the market overall, foreign giving is extremely concentrated. A handful of countries, including Qatar, England, China, and Saudi Arabia, account for a huge share of the roughly \$17 billion in the dataset, while schools like Cornell, Carnegie Mellon, Harvard, MIT, and Texas A&M capture many of the biggest individual gifts. Qatar leads in total dollars at about \$2.7 billion, while England leads in gift count with more than 3,600 gifts. That difference is pretty interesting because Qatar's giving comes from a smaller number of massive partnerships, while England looks more like a steady and high-volume donor base.

UVA has received about \$22.2 million across 98 foreign gifts, which puts us above the median institution but still well behind our closest peers. What stood out to me is that UVA's giving is not actually that concentrated. Our largest country only makes up about 19% of the total, so the bigger issue is that we just do not have enough countries in the mix. UVA is also behind peers in contract-based giving, with Contracts making up 67% of our total compared with roughly 84–89% at schools like Michigan, UT Austin, and UNC. That suggests we may be underusing sponsored research and institutional partnerships as a source of international funding.

Strategy for Growth

I would prioritize countries where peer institutions are already seeing meaningful giving but UVA receives little or none. China, Canada, Germany, Saudi Arabia, Hong Kong, Denmark, Portugal, and Ireland stand out, along with underdeveloped relationships in England and Japan. These are not completely speculative markets since they are already proven sources of funding for US universities. China and Germany seem like great starting points given their overall scale, especially through UVA's engineering, medicine, and data science programs.

There is also a real opportunity to grow through contracts and sponsored partnerships instead of focusing only on individual donors. UVA could work more closely with the research office and academic departments to identify faculty who already have international collaborators and help turn those relationships into larger institutional agreements. Even just having a few very strong partnerships could move the needle much more than relying on the slow accumulation of smaller gifts.

Conclusion

Overall, I think UVA is in a reasonably solid but clearly not top-tier position when it comes to foreign giving, and the trend line is a little concerning since our peer gap has been widening rather than closing in recent years. That said, the data suggests this is a fixable and well-defined problem rather than a fundamental weakness. We just aren't present in enough countries and we're underweighted in contract-based partnerships relative to schools we'd otherwise consider close peers. With a focused push into the whitespace countries identified above and a deliberate effort to grow sponsored research relationships alongside traditional gifts, I think UVA has a genuinely achievable path to closing a good chunk of that gap over the next several years.